lead, time is among the most dominant. As we continue to gain facility with superstring theory and its extension, M-theory, our cosmological insights will deepen, bringing both time's origin and its arrow into ever-sharper focus. If we let our imaginations run wild, we can even envision that the depth of our understanding will one day allow us to navigate spacetime and hence explore realms that, to this point in our experience, remain well beyond our ability to access (Chapter 15).

Of course, it is extremely unlikely that we will ever achieve such power. But even if we never gain the ability to control space and time, deep understanding yields its own empowerment. Our grasp of the true nature of space and time would be a testament to the capacity of the human intellect. We would finally come to know space and time—the silent, ever-present markers delineating the outermost boundaries of human experience.

Coming of Age in Space and Time

When I turned the last page of *The Myth of Sisyphus* many years ago, I was surprised by the text's having achieved an overarching feeling of optimism. After all, a man condemned to pushing a rock up a hill with full knowledge that it will roll back down, requiring him to start pushing anew, is not the sort of story that you'd expect to have a happy ending. Yet Camus found much hope in the ability of Sisyphus to exert free will, to press on against insurmountable obstacles, and to assert his choice to survive even when condemned to an absurd task within an indifferent universe. By relinquishing everything beyond immediate experience, and ceasing to search for any kind of deeper understanding or deeper meaning, Sisyphus, Camus argued, triumphs.

I was struck by Camus' ability to discern hope where most others would see only despair. But as a teenager, and only more so in the decades since, I found that I couldn't embrace Camus' assertion that a deeper understanding of the universe would fail to make life more rich or worthwhile. Whereas Sisyphus was Camus' hero, the greatest of scientists— Newton, Einstein, Niels Bohr, and Richard Feynman—became mine. And when I read Feynman's description of a rose—in which he explained how he could experience the fragrance and beauty of